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Explanatory model of well-being in victims of political violence in Colombia

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ABSTRACT

The present study aimed to validate an explanatory model of well-being among victims of the Colombian armed conflict, integrating variables of national identity, collective self-esteem, social support, social inclusion, and national self-stereotypes. A cross-sectional quantitative, associative, and explanatory design was implemented with 771 victims recognized by the Colombian State, residing in the Department of Atlántico. The sample predominantly consisted of women (72.2%), with a majority of adults over 40 years old, low educational attainment, and a high rate of unemployment. Internationally validated instruments adapted to the Colombian context were applied, including scales for national identification and attachment, collective self-esteem, social inclusion, social support, and subjective, social, and psychological well-being. Linear regression analyses showed limited explanatory power, whereas Random Forest machine learning models demonstrated excellent fit. Collective self-esteem and social inclusion were the most robust predictors of social and psychological well-being, while social support was the main predictor of subjective well-being. Identification with the nation displayed limited explanatory weight. Quantile regression indicated differential effects of the predictors depending on the levels of well-being, revealing, for instance, an ambivalent role of national attachment. The findings suggest that the well-being of victims of political violence is primarily mediated by collective and community resources rather than national identification. Implications are discussed for designing psychosocial interventions aimed at strengthening social cohesion, collective self-esteem, and support networks in vulnerable populations.

1. Introduction

The notion of national identity originates from studies on nationalism, whose philosophical scope and historical context go beyond the limits of this research. From a socio-anthropological (rather than political) perspective, nationalism can be understood as the ideas and feelings that underlie people's national identity (Greenfeld et al., 2003 (Greenfeld et al., 2003)). Social identity is understood as a component of overall identity and refers to the perception individuals have of themselves, integrating attributes such as culture, gender, socioeconomic status, social status, religious and political beliefs, among other individual and social traits (Espinosa et al., 2017 (Espinosa et al., 2017); Owens, 2006 (Owens and Delamater, 2006); Vignoles et al., 2006 (Vignoles et al., 2006)). Social identity also derives from individual self-concept, in which emotions of attachment to a group emerge, accompanied by affective evaluations (Turner, 1982 (Turner and Tajfel, 1982)). This concept aligns with national identity, which is a social form of identity focusing on individuals' membership to a nation (Espinosa and Tapia, 2011 (Espinosa and Tapia, 2011)). It evokes feelings of pride and the subjective experience of love and affection towards those with whom one shares history and learning within a social context (Ruíz and Carretero, 2010 (Ruiz and Carretero, 2010)).

This applied scientific research focuses on the analysis of several constructs explored in the social and behavioral sciences, where further interdisciplinary contributions are needed, especially from psychology and sociology (Gutiérrez, 2020 (Gutiérrez, 2020); Rizo, 2006 (Rizo, 2006)). There is thus a need to understand the set of distinguishing features, individual and objective characteristics, feelings, and

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attributes shared by members of a society. This is illustrated by the social identity theory proposed by Henri Tajfel and John Turner, which conceptualizes social identity as a relational process between individuals and their group(s), derived from self-knowledge and the emotional and evaluative meaning ascribed to the concept of "us" (Tajfel, 1984 (Tajfel, 1984)). This approach has provided insights into social problems such as inequality, stereotyping, discrimination, and the different manifestations of violence within social groups.

Social identity theory posits that maintaining a positive self-representation is relevant and significant for social groups, as it consolidates their collective self-esteem (Bar-Tal et al., 1996 (Bar-Tal et al., 1996)). Social identity encompasses the self-image individuals have regarding their social groups, how group interactions become positive or negative for individuals, and how such practices may foster or hinder the social development of communities (García, 2017 (García, 2017)). The concept of nation arises as a subtype of social identity (Espinosa et al., 2015 (Espinosa et al., 2015)). The sense of national identity is one of the diverse forms of collective identity generated by humans. National identity arises when a political and social organization system known as the nation-state is constituted (Espinosa et al., 2015 (Espinosa et al., 2015); Pérez, 1999 (Pérez, 1999)). State mechanisms use the human need for collective identification to instill national identification (Billig, 1995 (Billig, 1995); Pérez, 1999 (Pérez, 1999); Torsti, 2004 (Torsti, 2004)).

1.1. National context of the study

The literature has documented the serious consequences for mental health and behavior resulting from exposure to violent events (Cerquera et al., 2020 (Cerquera et al., 2020); Cudris-Torres and Barrios-Nuñez, 2018 (Cudris-Torres and Barrios-Núñez, 2018); Hewitt et al., 2016 (Hewitt et al., 2016); Osorio et al., 2019 (Osorio et al., 2018)). According to Parales (2004) (Parales, 2004), the conflict in Colombia has been associated with the disintegration of social forms of integration, leading to severe changes in the historical formation of a national identity. Consequently, Colombian society has naturalized the use of violence, aggression, inequality, and illegality as part of its identity (Parales, 2004) (Parales, 2004). Experiencing such events can significantly affect people's sense of belonging to a territory or nation and may also impact their collective sense of identity and the feelings and evaluations related to the concept of nation (Rambal et al., 2022) (Rambal et al., 2022). The national identity of the country has been built within a context of historical violence that has shaped the ideas of what the nation and its citizens are, giving rise to widely accepted stereotypes such as corruption or illegality (Parales, 2004) (Parales, 2004).

Arcila et al. (2012) (Arcila and Silva, 2012) evaluated the social injustice experienced by Colombian farmers, analyzing the effect of criminal violence on social variables such as collective self-esteem, community efficacy, and resilience. One notable finding was that communities with high crime rates exhibited reduced collective self-esteem, especially in the face of frequent threats. In societies affected by prolonged armed conflict, collective identities may play a complex role in shaping psychological well-being. Social identity theory suggests that belonging to meaningful social groups contributes to self-esteem and well-being. However, experiences of political violence, displacement, and institutional distrust may reshape individuals' identification with national communities. For victims of armed conflict, identification with the nation may coexist with feelings of exclusion or marginalization. For this reason, examining national identity alongside other psychosocial resources such as collective self-esteem, social support, and social inclusion may provide a more comprehensive understanding of the factors that contribute to well-being in post-conflict contexts.

The present research aims to identify the relationships between psychosocial factors related to social groups, such as collective self-esteem and social well-being, understood as cognitive indicators that facilitate social adjustment (Vignoles et al., 2006 (Vignoles et al., 2006); Simon, 2004 (Simon, 2004)). There is strong evidence supporting the benefits of social support for mental health (Aguerre and Bouffard, 2008 (Aguerre and Bouffard, 2008); Kleinspehn et al., 2008 (Kleinspehn et al., 2008); Vivaldi and Barra, 2012 (Vivaldi and Barra, 2012)); however, these processes require critical analysis, as not all forms of support are functional and some may have adverse effects (Bolger and Amarel, 2007 (Bolger and Amarel, 2007); Thoits, 2011 (Thoits, 2011); Uchino, 2009 (Uchino, 2009)). In vulnerable contexts, microsocial integration and network support may influence well-being positively or negatively depending on the type of assistance, accessibility, and the way in which group perception and social bonding are constructed (Tew et al., 2012) (Tew et al., 2012). Given the importance of these elements for the well-being of a population, this study aims to test a mental health model that integrates personal and community variables among vulnerable individuals, specifically victims of armed conflict.

1.2. Method

1.2.1. Design

This was an explanatory quantitative study with an associative strategy design (Ato et al., 2013) (Ato et al., 2013), employing an ex post facto retrospective approach with latent variables and a cross-sectional structure. The aim was to evaluate the effect of various independent variables on the dependent variable, providing explanatory insights into these relationships without direct manipulation of the variables, that is, to test models regarding the relationships among a set of variables.

1.2.2. Participants

Participants were selected through non-probabilistic purposive sampling, based on individual characteristics consistent with the study objectives, specifically being recognized victims of the Colombian armed conflict. The study involved 771 victims registered in the "Registro Único de Víctimas" (RUV), all of whom were adults residing in the Department of Atlántico. Most participants were women (n = 525; 72.2%), whereas 27.8% were men (n = 202). Regarding age, the majority were over 50 years old (n = 246; 33.8%), followed by adults aged 41–50 years (n = 172; 23.7%), and nearly equal proportions for those aged 20–30 years (n = 154; 21.2%) and 31–40 years (n = 153; 21%).

In terms of marital status, most reported being in a common-law union (n = 278; 38.2%), followed by single (n = 261; 36.1%), married (n = 101; 13.9%), separated or divorced (n = 47; 6.5%), and a low percentage of widowed participants (n = 36; 5.0%). Educational level distribution was as follows: secondary education (n = 305; 42.0%), primary (n = 210; 28.9%), technical level (n = 103; 14.2%), university level (n = 30; 4.1%), technological level (n = 24; 3.3%), currently studying a tertiary degree (n = 27; 3.7%), and only six (.8%) participants at the postgraduate level. Regarding employment, most reported being unemployed (n = 480; 66.0%), followed by those in informal work (n = 153; 21.8%), and a small proportion in formal employment (n = 69; 9.5%).

With respect to the type of victimizing event, most participants suffered forced displacement (n = 619; 80.2%), followed by enforced disappearance (n = 56; 7.2%), and torture, homicide, kidnapping, or landmine injuries among the remaining 96 (12.4%) participants.

1.2.3. Instruments

Sociodemographic Identification Form. Designed to collect information regarding age, biological sex, place of birth, educational level, marital status, employment status, victimizing events, among other characteristics relevant to the study population.

National Identification Scale (Vicente and Moreno, 2009) (Vicente and Moreno, 2009). This instrument consists of four items on a five-point Likert scale (1 = Not at all, 5 = Completely). The model fit is acceptable, with most goodness-of-fit statistics showing favorable values (χ^2/df = .75; RMR = .020; GFI = 1.00; RMSEA = .00).

National Attachment Scale (Huddy and Khatib, 2007) (Huddy and

Khatib, 2007). Comprising 15 items across three subscales: National Identity (4 items), Constructive Patriotism (4 items), and Uncritical Patriotism (7 items), all on a five-point Likert scale (1 = Not at all, 5 = Very much). Fit indices from international studies are satisfactory (χ^2/df = 3.47; CFI = .92; TLI = .90; RMSEA = .06).

National Self-stereotype Scale (Espinosa et al., 2016) (Espinosa et al., 2016). The transnational version includes Colombian populations and consists of 23 positive adjectives and their antonyms, indicating to what extent such attributes represent the participant's national in-group (Espinosa et al., 2017) (Espinosa et al., 2017). Uses a seven-point semantic differential scale (1 = agreement with positive adjective, 4 = neutral, 7 = agreement with negative adjective). The instrument groups items into four dimensions: Morality (α = .88), Competence (α = .83), Warmth (α = .82), and Ideal Nationalism (α = .81), with acceptable fit (χ^2/df = 4.92; RMR = .131; GFI = .888; CFI = .891; RMSEA = .07) (Espinosa et al., 2017) (Espinosa Pezzia et al., 2017).

Collective Self-Esteem Scale (Luhtanen and Crocker, 1992) (Luhtanen and Crocker, 1992). Widely used internationally, consists of 16 items with a seven-point Likert scale (1 = strongly disagree, 7 = strongly agree), measuring four subscales: membership (α = .73), private self-esteem (α = .74), public self-esteem (α = .79), and identity (α = .86).

Social Inclusion Scale (Secker et al., 2009) (Secker et al., 2009). Contains 17 items with a four-point Likert scale (1 = Never, 2 = Sometimes, 3 = Often, 4 = Always), divided into three subscales: Social Isolation (α = .76), Social Relationships (α = .76), and Social Acceptance (α = .70).

Social Well-Being Scale (Keyes, 1998) (Keyes, 1998). The edition by Blanco and Díaz (2005) (Blanco and Díaz, 2005), widely used in Colombia, was used in this study. Contains 15 items on a five-point Likert scale (1 = strongly disagree, 5 = strongly agree), covering five dimensions: integration (α = .69), acceptance (α = .83), contribution (α = .70), actualization (α = .79), and coherence (α = .68). Total internal consistency is .86, with robust fit statistics (χ^2/df = 789.28, GFI = .88, AGFI = .85, CFI = .85, RMSEA = .06).

Ryff's Psychological Well-Being Scale. Adapted by Díaz et al. (2006) (Díaz et al., 2006; Thoits, 2011) items using a six-point Likert scale (1 = strongly disagree, 6 = strongly agree), evaluates Self-Acceptance (α = .83), Positive Relations (α = .81), Autonomy (α = .73), Environmental Mastery (α = .71), Purpose in Life (α = .83), and Personal Growth (α = .68). Global reliability = .84; model fit is good (χ^2/df = 615.76, AIC = 788.16, CFI = .95, NFI = .94, SRMR = .05, RMSEA = .04).

MOS Social Support Questionnaire. Adapted for Colombian populations by Londoño et al. (2012) (Londoño et al., 2012), consists of 20 Likert-scale items measuring Emotional/Informational Support (α = .92), Instrumental Support (α = .79), Positive Social Interaction (α = .83), and Affective Support (α = .74). Total reliability = .94; fit is acceptable (GFI = .805, AGFI = .752, RMSEA = .097, AIC = 481.89, BIC = 612.57).

1.2.4. Procedure

All instruments were administered in person using self-administered paper questionnaires. In every case, ethical guidelines for contact, informed consent, anonymity, and voluntary withdrawal—per the recommendations of the Declaration of Helsinki—were strictly observed. No monetary compensation was provided for participation in this research.

Once the data were tabulated, a process to validate the data was conducted on a random, non-probabilistic sample, which consisted of spontaneously selecting 20 physical questionnaires and directly verifying them against entries in the database in order to detect digitization errors. Additionally, the scoring calculations for the applied instruments were checked, resulting in a positive balance that demonstrated the correct entry of the collected information.

1.2.5. Data analysis

The data analysis was conducted in several phases to evaluate the necessary assumptions for predictive modeling and to compare the effectiveness of distinct nonlinear approaches in predicting well-being indicators. First, a descriptive analysis of sociodemographic variables was performed to characterize the participants, followed by a general overview of the main variables measured by the instruments.

Distributions of variables were then explored using skewness and kurtosis coefficients and the Kolmogorov-Smirnov and Shapiro-Wilk tests for normality. In all cases, the results rejected the null hypothesis of normality ($p < .001$), showing distributions that deviated from Gaussian expectations. Logarithmic transformations were applied to attenuate skewness; however, these did not achieve optimal adjustment, and significant deviations in normality tests remained.

Multicollinearity was assessed through bivariate correlations and the calculation of the Variance Inflation Factor (VIF). The results indicated an absence of significant multicollinearity, as correlation coefficients remained below .40 and VIF values were within acceptable ranges. These values, along with moderate mean errors, reflected the inability of a polynomial model to capture the complexity of the relationships among variables. As a result, the need to apply more robust nonparametric models such as the Random Forest Regressor was considered, which ultimately demonstrated substantially superior performance. To examine how relationships varied throughout the distribution of well-being, quantile regression models were also estimated. Random Forest models were used to estimate the relative importance of psychosocial predictors of well-being. This machine-learning technique allows the modeling of complex nonlinear relationships and interactions between variables without requiring strict parametric assumptions. Additionally, quantile regression analyses were conducted to examine how predictor variables behave across different points of the well-being distribution, providing a more detailed perspective on the heterogeneity of these relationships.

2. Results

The results section focuses on describing each of the theoretical variables, followed by a statistical modeling proposal based on viability analyses. The first analyzed variable was the degree of identification with the nation, calculated using quartiles for low, medium, and high levels. The minimum score was 4, the maximum was 20, with a mean of 18.65 and a standard deviation of 2.90. Most participants were at the Medium (68.5%) and Low (31.5%) levels.

The second construct analyzed was national attachment, which comprises three subscales: National Identity (NI), Constructive Patriotism (CP), and Uncritical Patriotism (UP). For the first subscale (NI), minimum and maximum values were 4 and 20, respectively, with a mean of 19.05 and a standard deviation of 2.9. For the second subscale (CP), the minimum and maximum were 4 and 20, mean 18.02, standard deviation 2.6. For the third subscale (UP), the minimum was 7, the maximum 35, mean 26.28 and standard deviation 6.5. The quartile distribution indicated that, for NI and CP, most participants were at medium or high levels, while UP showed a more even distribution across all levels (see Table 1).

The third scale evaluated was Collective Self-Esteem, consisting of four subscales: Membership (M), Private Self-Esteem (PR), Public Self-Esteem (PU), and Identity (I). For Membership, the minimum was 4,

Table 1
Quartile distribution of the National Attachment Scale.

Measure	IN		PC		PA		Scale
	Value	*%*	*Value*	*%*	*Value*	*%*	
Quartile	19	31.5	16	26.5	21	26.0	Low
Quartile	20	68.5	19	24.5	26	24.2	Medium
Quartile	20	.0	20	49.0	32	26.5	High

maximum 28, mean 17.33, standard deviation 5.3. For Private Self-Esteem, min 4, max 28, mean 16.94, standard deviation 5.2. For Public Self-Esteem, min 3, max 28, mean 17.44, standard deviation 5.2. For Identity, min 4, max 28, mean 18.33, standard deviation 5.7. As shown in Table 2, the distribution is varied: for Membership, Identity, and Public Self-Esteem, most data fall in the low and high levels; for Private Self-Esteem, the medium level dominates.

Social Inclusion, for its three subscales—Social Isolation (SI), Social Relationships (SR), and Social Acceptance (SA)—showed the following descriptive results: SI min 3, max 37, mean 21.40, standard deviation 4.1; SR min 4, max 28, mean 17.23, standard deviation 4.5; SA min 3, max 19, mean 14.38, standard deviation 2.3. The quartile analysis reveals high levels in SI and SA, and medium for SR, indicating generally good inclusion (see Table 3).

The National Self-stereotypes scale contains four subscales: Morality (M), Warmth (W), Competence (C), and Ideal Nationalism (IN). Morality: min 6, max 53, mean 32.59, sd 10.7; Warmth: min 6, max 42, mean 30.34, sd 10.2; Competence: min 6, max 42, mean 30.75, sd 11.2; Ideal Nationalism: min 3, max 21, mean 15.04, sd 5.3. The quartile distribution shows a prevalence of the low level only in Ideal Nationalism, while high levels dominate in Morality, Warmth, and Competence (Table 4).

The Social Support (MOS) Scale, which considers the number of close friends and family, yielded averages of 4.1 and 6.4, respectively. It is composed of four subscales: Emotional/Informational Support (EIS), Instrumental Support (IS), Affective Support (AS), and Positive Social Interaction (PSI). EIS: min 4, max 24, mean 15.22, sd 4.5; IS: min 8, max 58, mean 30.9, sd 8.1; AS: min 3, max 18, mean 12.49, sd 2.9; PSI: min 3, max 24, mean 15.51, sd 4.3. Quartile analysis reveals predominance of high levels in AS, PSI, and EIS (Table 5).

Social Well-being, with a minimum score of 25, maximum 175, mean 96.24, and standard deviation 26.7, shows an almost homogeneous distribution among levels (Table 6).

The Subjective Well-being Scale: min 5, max 32, mean 15.35, sd 6.3. Distribution is nearly homogeneous among the different levels (Table 7).

Finally, the Psychological Well-being Scale: min 29, max 217, mean 126.4, sd 26.6, also presents a nearly even distribution across levels (Table 8).

2.1. Assumption evaluation

Preliminary analyses indicated that none of the variables met the established criteria for normality. Both skewness and kurtosis coefficients, as well as Kolmogorov-Smirnov and Shapiro-Wilk tests, rejected the null hypothesis of normal distribution ($p < .001$ in all cases). Although logarithmic transformations were applied to reduce skewness, these failed to achieve a satisfactory fit, with significant values persisting on normality indicators.

Regarding multicollinearity, bivariate correlations were below .40 and the Variance Inflation Factor (VIF) values remained under 5, thus confirming relative independence among predictors and the feasibility of their inclusion in multivariate models. Initially, a second-order nonlinear regression model was adjusted. The results showed limited explanatory power: social well-being ($R^2 = .123$), subjective well-being ($R^2 = .193$), and psychological well-being ($R^2 = .155$). Despite the inclusion of quadratic terms, the model did not adequately capture the complexity of the relationships among psychosocial variables and well-being indicators.

Table 3
Quartile distribution of the Social Inclusion Scale.

Measure	AS		RS		ACS		Scale
	Value	%	Value	%	Value	%	
Quartile	19	26.3	14	30.3	13	26.8	Low
Quartile	22	29.7	17	27.4	15	24.2	Medium
Quartile	25	29.8	20	19.1	16	48.7	High

3. Random Forest models

Subsequently, Random Forest models were estimated, which demonstrated outstanding performance. Social well-being reached an R^2 of .856, subjective well-being an R^2 of .886, and psychological well-being an R^2 of .869, with very low mean square errors (MSE <.03; MAE <.12). This indicates that the model explains 85.6% of the variance for social well-being, representing an excellent adjustment; both mean squared error and mean absolute error are very low, confirming that non-linear relationships exist between predictor and outcome variables.

With regard to the relative importance of predictors, collective self-esteem played a central role in explaining social and psychological well-being, whereas social support was the most influential predictor for subjective well-being. Social inclusion was also highlighted as a relevant variable across all three models. In contrast, identification with the nation showed a reduced predictive weight. Table 9 presents the fit indices for the three well-being scales according to the proposed model.

As seen, all well-being scales showed excellent fit, guaranteeing a strong structure for the proposed model. The contribution or importance of each predictor variable within this model was also assessed; Table 10 provides this detail for each well-being scale.

These indices demonstrate that for social and psychological well-being, the strongest predictor is collective self-esteem, whereas social support is the main predictor for subjective well-being. The high R^2 values observed in the Random Forest models should be interpreted with caution. While these results reflect the capacity of non-linear models to capture complex interactions, they may also raise concerns regarding potential overfitting. To complement this interpretation, additional performance metrics such as mean squared error (MSE) and mean absolute error (MAE) were considered, both indicating low prediction error. These findings reflect explanatory power within the sample rather than generalizability.

4. Quantile regression

Finally, quantile regression analysis enabled observation of variations in predictor effects across the distribution of well-being (see Table 11).

Considering the above, it is important to note that this analysis confirms that for social well-being, social inclusion was positively and significantly associated in the medium and high quantiles, while national attachment showed a negative effect at the median. For subjective well-being, social support presented negative effects in the medium and high quantiles, while national attachment emerged as a positive predictor only at high levels. Finally, for psychological well-being, national attachment, social inclusion, and social support were significant across all three quantiles, demonstrating consistent effects across different well-being levels.

Table 2
Quartile distribution of the Collective Self-Esteem Scale.

Measure	A		PR		PU		I		Scale
	Value	*%*	*Value*	*%*	*Value*	*%*	*Value*	*%*	
Quartile	16	56.0	15	25.6	16	50.1	16	43.9	Low
Quartile	16	.0	16	34.9	16	.0	18	8.4	Medium
Quartile	21	21.7	20	16.6	21	26.5	22	27.0	High

Table 4
Quartile distribution of the National Self-stereotypes Scale.

Measure	M		C		CO		N		Scale
	Value	%	Value	%	Value	%	Value	%	
Quartile	27	27.51	24	29.57	24	28.89	12	32.19	Low
Quartile	33	24.76	33	24.21	34	21.46	15	18.43	Medium
Quartile	41	23.93	39	22.15	41	25.58	20	26.13	High

Table 5
Quartile distribution of the Social Support Scale (MOS).

Measure	AM		AS		AA		ISP		Scale
	Value	%	Value	%	Value	%	Value r	%	
Quartile	12	28.34	24	26.1	11	30.9	12	25.7	Low
Quartile	16	26.82	32	24.3	14	29.3	16	26.0	Medium
Quartile	20	44.57	39	27.6	15	39.6	20	48.1	High

Table 6
Quartiles of the keyes social well-being scale.

Measure	Value	%	Scale
Quartile	80.5	25.0	Low
Quartile	96	25.2	Medium
Quartile	114	25.4	High

Table 7
Quartiles of the diener subjective well-being scale.

Measure	Valor	%	Scale
Quartile	10	27.2	High
Quartile	15	24.1	Medium
Quartile	20	25.2	Low

Table 8
Quartiles of the ryff psychological well-being scale.

Measure	Value	%	Scale
Quartile	116	25.6	High
Quartile	130	26.9	Medium
Quartile	141	24.0	Low

Table 9
Random Forest model results for well-being.

Dependent Variable	R^2	MSE	MAE	Interpretation
Social Well-being	.856	.015	.078	Excellent fit
Subjective Well-being	.886	.026	.122	Excellent fit
Psychological well-being	.869	.008	.057	Excellent fit

Table 10
Importance of predictive variables in Random Forest.

Predictor Variable	Social well-being	Subjective well-being	Psychological well-being
Collective Self-Esteem	.244	.207	.243
Social Inclusion	.219	.167	.189
Social Support	.186	.233	.208
National Self-stereotypes	.171	.170	.173
National Attachment	.130	.179	.144
Identification w/ Nation	.047	.044	.043

Table 11
Main results of quantile regression.

Dependent Variable	Quantile	Significant predictors ($p < .05$)
Social Well-Being	.25	None
	.50	National Attachment (−), Social Inclusion (+)
	.75	Social Inclusion (+), National Self-stereotypes (+)
Subjective Well-Being	.25	Collective Self-Esteem (+), Social Inclusion (+), Social Support (−)
	.50	Social Support (−)
	.75	National Attachment (+), Social Support (−)
Psychological Well-Being	.25	National Attachment (+), Social Inclusion (+), Social Support (+)
	.50	National Identification (−), National Attachment (+), Social Inclusion (+),
	.75	Collective Self-Esteem (+), National Self-stereotypes (+), Social Support (+)

5. Discussion

The findings indicate that the majority of participants harbor ideas and sentiments that underpin their national identity, yielding a mean score of 18.65 on the national identification scale. This aligns with the Social Identity Theory of Tajfel and Turner (1986) (Tajfel et al., 1986), which postulates that belonging to a social group contributes to collective self-esteem. However, it was also observed that experiences of victimization and displacement negatively impact both collective self-esteem and national identification. For instance, 80.2% of participants reported having been displaced, which is consistent with previous studies highlighting the impact of violence on national identity and psychological well-being (Arcila et al., 2012 (Arcila and Silva, 2012); Parales, 2004 (Parales, 2004)).

The relationship between collective self-esteem and psychological well-being has been extensively studied across various contexts. For example, Henríquez et al. (2021) (Henríquez et al., 2021) found that collective self-esteem and ethnic identity show positive correlations with nearly all dimensions of psychological well-being among Colombian migrants in Chile. This study underscores the importance of collective identity as a protective factor against the negative effects of perceived discrimination and acculturation stress (Smith and Silva, 2011 (Smith and y Sylva, 2011); Balidemaj and Small, 2019 (Balidemaj and Small, 2019); De et al., 2023 (De Lise et al., 2023); Espinosa et al., 2015 (Espinosa et al., 2015)).

Regarding the proposed model, the results provide robust evidence concerning the non-linear nature of the relationships between psychosocial variables and well-being indicators. In line with previous research emphasizing the multifactorial complexity of well-being (Diener et al., 2018 (Diener et al., 2018); Keyes, 2020 (Keyes, 2020)), linear models

proved insufficient to explain the variance of the dependent variables, whereas Random Forest models more effectively captured the underlying interactions and patterns. A central contribution of this work lies in the identification of collective self-esteem, social support, and social inclusion as the most relevant predictors across the different dimensions of well-being.

In terms of the social psychology of identity, these results support the thesis that membership in meaningful groups and the positive valuation of such memberships constitute a "psychosocial resource" that fosters resilience and coping in stressful situations (Haslam et al., 2019 (Haslam et al., 2019); Tajfel and Turner, 1986 (Tajfel et al., 1986)). Furthermore, the relevance of social support aligns with accumulated evidence regarding its protective role against anxious and depressive symptomatology (Cohen and Wills, 1985 (Cohen and Wills, 1985); Lakey et al., 2010 (Lakey et al., 2010)). The significance of collective self-esteem and social inclusion coincides with theories underlining the centrality of a sense of belonging and positive group valuation in the construction of psychological well-being (Tajfel and Turner, 1986 (Tajfel et al., 1986); Haslam et al., 2019 (Haslam et al., 2019)). Likewise, the role of social support as a key predictor of subjective well-being reinforces findings in the literature regarding its protective function against emotional distress and as a facilitator of coping resources (Cohen and Wills, 1985 (Cohen and Wills, 1985); Lakey et al., 2010 (Lakey et al., 2010)).

Quantile regression provided additional nuances, demonstrating that predictors do not act uniformly across the distribution of well-being. For example, national attachment may have negative effects at median levels of social well-being but positive effects at high levels of subjective and psychological well-being. This finding suggests that national bonding may operate differentially depending on individual contexts, representing both a resource and a source of tension according to the level of well-being achieved. Social inclusion showed a particularly significant positive effect at median and high levels of social well-being, suggesting that social networks and community participation opportunities acquire greater value for individuals who already enjoy a certain degree of well-being. In contrast, national attachment presented an ambivalent pattern: negatively associated with social well-being at the median, but positively with subjective and psychological well-being at the highest levels. This ambivalence invites consideration that national identification may be a protective or risk factor depending on the sociopolitical context, the type of patriotism (constructive vs. uncritical), and the way national values are internalized (Mummendey et al., 2001 (Mummendey et al., 2001)).

The results suggest that collective and community-based psychosocial resources play a central role in explaining well-being among victims of political violence. Collective self-esteem and perceptions of social inclusion emerged as stronger predictors than national identification. These findings highlight the importance of strengthening community ties and promoting inclusive social environments as part of psychosocial recovery processes in post-conflict settings.

These findings are consistent with previous research conducted in Colombia, which has highlighted the central role of self-esteem, perceived control, and social support in the well-being of populations affected by armed conflict (e.g., Hewitt Ramírez et al., 2016; Cudris-Torres and Barrios-Núñez, 2018). Similar patterns have also been documented in other Latin American contexts, where psychosocial resources such as collective identity and social integration are key determinants of well-being in vulnerable populations.

In contexts of vulnerability, social support does not always operate as a uniformly positive resource. Certain forms of support may reinforce dependency, activate traumatic memories, or be perceived as stigmatizing assistance. Consequently, the effects of social support may vary depending on the level of well-being and the subjective meaning attributed to support networks.

In addition, qualitative studies have shown that experiences of violence and displacement reshape meanings of belonging, trust, and social support, suggesting that these constructs operate within complex sociocultural frameworks. From this perspective, well-being cannot be fully understood without considering the historical and territorial contexts in which individuals are embedded.

It is also important to acknowledge that the effects observed in this study may vary across regions and populations. The dynamics of the armed conflict and its psychosocial consequences differ between regions such as the Caribbean and Pacific areas of Colombia, as well as across population groups, including Afro-Colombian communities or internally displaced persons in different territories. Future research should further explore these contextual variations in order to refine psychosocial intervention strategies.

Altogether, the results allow for the conclusion that well-being is a construct sensitive to social and collective dynamics, where the interaction between collective self-esteem, social inclusion, and support constitutes a relevant explanatory core. The use of non-parametric approaches and machine learning techniques is thus presented as an ideal methodological pathway to address complex phenomena in social and well-being psychology. In summary, this study contributes to the field of social psychology by providing evidence on the validity of instruments for measuring national identity in contexts of vulnerability. The findings highlight the need to address the psychological consequences of violence and promote national identity as a resource for well-being and resilience in affected populations (Espinosa et al., 2015 (Espinosa et al., 2015); Windari, 2021 (Windari, 2021)). The integration of these results with existing literature emphasizes the importance of collective self-esteem, social support, and social inclusion in promoting psychological well-being, especially in contexts of adversity.

From an applied perspective, these results offer relevant implications for the design of policies and intervention programs. First, strategies aimed at strengthening collective self-esteem—for instance, through educational and community initiatives that promote positive valuation of the group of belonging—can have significant effects on social and psychological well-being. Second, investment in social support networks, particularly in their emotional and instrumental dimensions, constitutes a fundamental strategy for promoting subjective well-being in vulnerable populations. Finally, fostering social inclusion by guaranteeing active participation in community life and reducing isolation emerges as a transversal protective factor across various levels of well-being.

The results also underscore the importance of developing interventions that strengthen national identity and collective self-esteem in populations affected by violence. Reparation and psychological support programs that promote a sense of belonging and social cohesion may be crucial for improving the well-being of these communities. In conclusion, it is essential to understand the set of distinctive traits, individual and objective characteristics, feelings, and attributes shared by members of a society. Furthermore, the attributes that constitute individuals, together with the social context in which they are immersed, can serve as indicators of the identity traits of the social group to which they belong. This is explained through the Social Identity Theory proposed by Henri Tajfel and John Turner, understood as the result of a relational process between the individual and their group or groups. This process derives from the individual's self-knowledge and the evaluative and emotional significance they assign to the concept of "us," which allows them to generate a sense of belonging to a specific social space (Tajfel, 1984 (Tajfel, 1984)).

Since its inception, the social identity approach has provided answers to social problems such as inequality, value judgments, discrimination, and various manifestations of violence within social groups. In populations affected by armed conflict, social inclusion acquires a restorative role against the sociocultural and community damages derived from political violence (Schoof Aguirre et al., 2018 (Schoof et al., 2018)). These authors highlight that the rupture of community ties, social distrust, and isolation—frequent sequels of forced displacement—directly impact the loss of a sense of collective identity. Within this framework, community integration processes allow for the

reconstruction of meaningful social networks and the restoration of a sense of belonging, favoring the positive resignification of "us."

This study has several limitations that should be considered when interpreting the findings. First, the use of non-probabilistic purposive sampling and the focus on participants from a single department (Atlántico) limit the generalizability of the results to other regions of Colombia. The dynamics of the armed conflict and its psychosocial consequences may vary substantially across regions, such as between Caribbean and Pacific areas, as well as across different population groups, including Afro-Colombian communities or internally displaced persons in diverse territorial contexts. Second, the cross-sectional design precludes causal inferences regarding the relationships between psychosocial variables and well-being. Finally, the quantitative nature of the study limits the exploration of subjective meanings of well-being and social belonging. Future research would benefit from incorporating qualitative or mixed-method approaches to better capture the complexity of these processes in post-conflict settings.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Ailed Marenco-Escuderos: Writing – review & editing, Validation, Resources, Methodology, Investigation, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Margel Parra-Fernández:** Writing – review & editing, Validation, Supervision, Resources, Methodology, Investigation, Funding acquisition, Conceptualization. **Rosa Hernández-Bustos:** Validation, Methodology, Formal analysis, Data curation. **Yolima Alarcon-Vásquez:** Writing – original draft, Validation, Resources, Methodology, Investigation, Conceptualization. **Sandra Quintero-Gonzalez:** Writing – original draft, Resources, Methodology, Investigation, Conceptualization. **Hansel Duque-Rhenals:** Writing – review & editing, Validation, Methodology, Investigation. **Andrea Puerta-Pérez:** Writing – review & editing, Resources, Methodology, Investigation, Data curation. **Laura Rambal-Rivaldo:** Validation, Resources, Methodology, Investigation, Conceptualization.

Consent for publication

All individual participants consented to the publication of their non-personal data.

Availability of data and materials

The data supporting the findings of this study are available from the corresponding author upon reasonable request.

Ethics approval and consent to participate

This study was approved by the Research and Development Ethics Committee of the Corporación Universitaria Reformada (No. 02, April 22, 2022). All participants provided written informed consent prior to their inclusion in the study. This research was conducted ethically in accordance with the World Medical Association Declaration of Helsinki.

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Declaration of competing interest

The authors declare that there are no conflicts of interest associated with the development of the research, the preparation of the manuscript, or its publication.

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List of Abbreviations

RUV	Single Registry of Victims (*Registro Único de Víctimas*)
χ^2/gl	Chi-square/degrees of freedom
RMR	Root Mean Square Residual
GFI	Goodness of Fit Index
RMSEA	Root Mean Square Error of Approximation
CFI	Comparative Fit Index
TLI	Tucker-Lewis Index
AIC	Akaike Information Criterion
NFI	Normed Fit Index
SRMR	Standardized Root Mean Square Residual
BIC	Bayesian Information Criterion
NI	National Identity (*Identidad Nacional*)
CP	Constructive Patriotism
UP	Uncritical Patriotism
M	Membership.
PrS	Private Self-esteem
PuS	Public Self-esteem
I	Identity
SI	Social Isolation
SR	Social Relations
SA	Social Acceptance
M	Morality
W	Warmth
C	Competence
IN	Ideal Nationalism
EIS	Emotional/Informational Support
IS	Instrumental Support
AS	Affective Support
PSI	Positive Social Interaction

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